UCLA Samueli
Civil & Environmental Engineering

Awards Selection Committee
Distinguished TA Awards,
UCLA

Sub: Departmental Support Letter for Samatha Arun

Dear Award Committee,

I am pleased to provide this Departmental letter in strong support of Ms. Arun's application for the UCLA's Distinguished Teaching Award. I also serve as the Vice Chair for Graduate Studies in the Civil & Environmental Engineering Department. Ms. Arun has served as the TAC for the Teaching Assistant Training Seminar course C&EE 495, and I had the opportunity to closely observe her performance during Fall 2025, when I was the instructor of record. For C&EE 495: *Teaching Assistant Training Seminar* (Fall 2021–2025, five quarters), she led the seminar, mentored and provided feedback to TAs, held office hours, and designed classroom activities, culminating in the creation of a TA Handbook. In addition to this course, Ms. Arun has held multiple TA roles in courses such as C&EE 255B and for the Cluster M1CW: Food. In writing this letter, I was also able to review the SET's Ms. Arun shared with me for the courses she has TA'd.

Across multiple teaching roles, Ms. Arun has served as a TA for three courses. For C&EE 255B: *Biological Processes for Water and Wastewater Treatment* (Winter 2021–2023, three quarters), she led discussion sections, held office hours, graded all but the midterm and final, and created visual aids/handouts that students deeply appreciated, as reflected in SET survey excerpts. Most recently, for CLUSTER M1CW: *Food: Lens for Environment and Sustainability—Special Topics: From Fork to Future: Intersection of Health, Wealth, Culture, and Sustainability* (Spring 2025, one quarter), she led the seminar, managed grading and feedback, held office hours, and helped design this Writing II seminar, including securing a TLC seed grant—with departmental endorsement from C&EE—to incorporate a teaching kitchen workshop into the course.

Ms. Arun implemented evidence-based, best-practice teaching through active, inclusive, and experiential learning strategies. In C&EE 495, she designed a rubric-based Lego activity to highlight equitable and transparent grading, and students noted that she created an inclusive, engaging learning environment. In CLUSTER M1CW, she extended learning beyond the classroom with a "Meatless Monday" teaching kitchen workshop that connected food sustainability to daily life and was praised as a valuable, hands-on way to build community and develop research and cooking skills.

Beyond required training, Ms. Arun sought out the TAC role early-on in her PhD and attended the TAC Academy every year since 2021. She has enrolled and attended several teaching preparation events including ENGCOMP 495N: *Teaching Preparation: Writing-Intensive Seminar Development* and GRAD PD 496B: *Teaching as Research* (TAR). Crucially, Ms. Arun provided valuable guidance and mentorship to budding TAs throughout as the department's TAC.

In closing, on behalf of the C&EE department, I offer Ms. Arun my strongest support for the award.

Sincerely,



Sriram Narasimhan, PhD, P.Eng (Ont), F.ASCE,

Professor and Graduate Vice Chair, C&EE

My teaching is guided by a simple goal: help students succeed in challenging material by making expectations clear, making thinking visible, and creating learning environments where questions and growth are normalized. Whether I am supporting graduate students in a rigorous engineering course, guiding undergraduates through writing and systems thinking about food and sustainability, or preparing new TAs to teach with confidence, I use evidence-based practices to turn complexity into clarity.

In C&EE 255B, a graduate-level wastewater treatment class, I focused on helping graduate students succeed in a technically dense course by reducing avoidable barriers. Drawing on my own recent experience as a student in the course, I anticipated common pain points and designed each discussion section to re-teach key concepts with clearer structure, step-by-step reasoning, and ample time for questions. This scaffolding approach was paired with cognitive load-reducing supports: I created concise handouts that consolidated “must-know” operating parameters and drew visual schematics of treatment processes and the wastewater nitrogen cycle, using color-coded reaction pathways to help students translate equations into mental models they could apply on exams and in design problems.[3] My handouts were well received by both the students and the professor who adopted them into the course material[1] and utilizes them even today. Students consistently described my sections as pivotal to their understanding of the course material expressing my “dedication to this course” and “ability to synthesize difficult material” “clearly demonstrated an expertise on the subject” and “provided great context outside of what we learned during lectures.”[1]

In M1CW: From Fork to Future, I designed a writing-intensive seminar that helps students move from personal experience to systems-level analysis and then to persuasive, evidence-based writing about food, sustainability, and equity. Using backward design, I aligned learning outcomes, weekly themes, and assessment so that students repeatedly practiced the skills required for the final holistic report, including credible-source research, synthesis, and claim-building through writing and discussion,[2] all of which can be quite daunting for a freshman.To support this growth without intimidation, I used writing-to-learn pedagogy through weekly writing tasks that asked students to communicate complex ideas in a variety of authentic and engaging genres.[2] These tasks were preceded by dialogue-rich peer research and discussion routines to promote collaborative learning. I also included activities that helped students map their interests and goals for the final project. A faculty observation noted that the class was clearly structured and that the writing process was emphasized through prewriting and mapping activities that helped students translate research into purposeful communication for a specific audience and tone.[2] To emphasize relevance and the power of consumer choices, I incorporated a “Meatless Monday” workshop in collaboration with UCLA’s Teaching Kitchen through TLC’s seed grant, which students described as valuable.[1] Students also described this structure as transformative, sharing that the course “widened my perspective” and that metacognitive assignments like weekly food diaries helped them “reexamine the impacts of my own diet on things like health and the environment.”[1]

In C&EE 495, I approached TA training as practice-based professional development that prioritizes transferable teaching skills, not passive exposure to policies. I designed sessions

around concrete instructional decisions that new TAs face immediately, and I built in active learning so trainees could test ideas, reflect, and revise their approach. One example is the Lego-based rubric activity, where groups build a structure from written criteria, making the consequences of vague expectations visible and creating a shared experience to discuss grading clarity, fairness, and consistency.[4] To support transfer beyond the seminar, I created a TA handbook that functions as a practical job aid, including an engagement toolkit, a curated resource inventory, sample welcome survey questions that center on belonging and access, and micro-teaching feedback.[4] Students noted that I was “committed to us being good TAs and feeling supported” and that they felt “much more confident in TA-ing after this class.”[1]

Beyond my role as a TAC, I have routinely sought opportunities to expand my pedagogical knowledge and translate it into practice. I completed the CIRTL@UCLA Associate Certification[5] and am currently pursuing practitioner-level development through GRAD PD 496B, where I am planning and implementing a teaching-as-research project. Together, these experiences reflect an ongoing improvement cycle. I study what helps students learn, apply inclusive and active practices in the classroom, and use evidence to continually refine my teaching so that all my students can thrive with clarity, confidence, and ownership of their learning.

[1] Artifact 1 - SET Survey Excerpts; [2] Artifact 2 - M1CW; [3] Artifact 3 - 255B; [4] Artifact 4 - 495; [5] Artifact 5 - CIRTL Certification

"Learning is something students do to themselves; not something you can do to them" is what I open with every year I teach the class on *How Students Learn* in my department's 495 TA training seminar. You cannot force knowledge into people's brains, but it is in your power as an instructor to create an environment where each member of the community, with varying depths of prerequisite knowledge, is able to succeed. Therefore, I tend to assume that at least half the students don't have adequate knowledge structures and prepare my material accordingly.

On the flip side, instructors should also be mindful of the time students are choosing to invest in their classroom and make sure every bit of that time feels worthwhile. Covering basics with a well-prepared cohort can feel like a waste of time and lead to disengagement, so I get to know my students and adapt through welcome surveys and real-time verbal and non-verbal feedback. In fact, if I were to describe my teaching style in one word, it would be adaptive. I calibrate my approach to the course, my audience, and the needs of my students in the context of the course. One size does not fit all, and it never will, but being prepared for a variety of needs with some foresight is a practice that I not only recommend to the budding TAs I mentor but also model in my own sections.

I also hold that the learning curve of students is a direct reflection of the instructional impact and classroom experience. I want my students to leave my class feeling like somebody really cares about their well-being and is committed to their academic progress. When I look back on my own experience as a high school, undergraduate, and graduate student, my "success" in any given course bore no correlation to the complexity of the material presented to me, but was significantly influenced by my personal interest in the themes of the course, my general curiosity in learning something I didn't know, and was particularly associated with the instructor's intentionality. Every time I had a teacher who was invested in ensuring student learning, as opposed to just lecturing, I was motivated to do well in that class. It would be shortsighted to assume my experience to be universal, but observing my classmates and the students I have taught over the years, I do see some merit in assuming that teaching efficacy is directly linked to students' success and sense of belonging. Therefore, I emulate the qualities I observed in exemplary teachers either by intentionally scaffolding complex material, generating visual handouts informed by my graphic design skills, creating an inclusive environment where students feel comfortable speaking out, or simply providing clear written and verbal instructions to reduce avoidable cognitive burden.

Everyone's educational journey is different, and when you are attempting to teach another human being, you are not just up against varying gaps in knowledge and myriad misconceptions; you are also tackling lived experiences, existing perceptions of teaching and learning, and their view of themselves and their abilities, which can be slightly more complicated to deal with. I am committed to the idea that every member of a learning community is inherently valuable, and their mastery of the course content does not diminish or increase that value. This is why I not only adapt my lessons to the depths of my students' knowledge, but also to the breadth of my audience.

If we were to evaluate student success only by their grades, then a student whose entire motivation hinges upon getting an “A” will go out of their way to secure resources and reach out for help to achieve that goal. But a student driven by more intrinsic types of motivation and/or seeking a deeper learning experience will benefit from an instructor who makes those building blocks of knowledge and academic growth more accessible through their overall engagement and handling of course logistics. Plus, the grade-motivated students benefit from it as well! I routinely put myself in the shoes of those students who are not grade-motivated, the students facing crises, and the ones balancing other responsibilities. When planning my syllabus, I build in guardrails for students facing steep barriers by offering multimodal paths to the same learning milestone and flexible make-up options for assessments missed due to unforeseen circumstances. In pedagogical circles, we call that “student-centered learning,” “universal design,” or “inclusive teaching practices.” I like to call it empathy. It is an overused but powerful sentiment to lead with in any group setting, and a reminder to us all not to forget where we all once started.

My core belief system and approach to teaching are significantly shaped by being a high-functioning neurodivergent kid who was able to escape diagnosis well into adulthood. No, this isn’t a sympathy card, but it does give me some insight into what it feels like to be in a learning community and not relate to the experiences of your peers, both positive and negative ones at that. It leaves you with an internal narrative of inadequacy and a fragile sense of belonging. Then you grow up and realize that everyone feels that way to some degree, and even though their experiences of feeling “different” might not be as intense, they are still different, unique even. So why fight against the beauty of individuality? And why not make that the baseline assumption? Wouldn’t that lead to a more resilient community and better learning outcomes? A place where you do not need to hide your struggles, and people do not think less of you for having them in the first place.

Since I started with the cliché of beginning this statement with a quote, I would like to go full circle and end with another quote, one that I used during my micro-teaching as a young PhD student and novice educator enrolled in my department’s 495 course:

“Conformity is what really killed the cat!” —Samatha Arun

C&EE 255B: Biological Processes for Water and Wastewater Treatment (Winter 2021-23)
“Sam is one of the best TAs I've had. She is so knowledgeable, organized, and skilled at communicating class concepts. She helps us understand the material as it pertains to our homework assignments and just makes the course more manageable in general. Plus she's just such a wonderful person, always willing to help and answer any questions we have. Thanks so much!”

“Samatha is an exceptional teaching assistant. She effectively taught the course outright, with many students openly remarking during rambling lecture presentations in the main course that it was going to be all right, because Sam would teach us whatever the topic was supposed to be in section. The professor outright used tools Sam made as teaching tools in the class. Her dedication to this course, ability to synthesize difficult material I would not have learned otherwise, and willingness to interpret obtuse homework instructions for us made her far and away the best and most supportive part of the course.”

“The TA did a great job at giving us the information needed to succeed in homework and on the exams. Her PowerPoints and notes were detailed and clear, and after attending her sessions I felt like I understood the material so much better.”

“This TA was incredibly helpful each and every week and provided amazing help throughout the course. Students always felt comfortable asking questions and the answers to them clearly demonstrated an expertise on the subject. Samatha could easily be a professor in her own manner as these discussions were organized very well and provided great context outside of what we learned during lectures”

“She was a great TA. She is one of the few TAs I actually enjoyed going for discussion class. I liked the materials and she organized materials on CCLE. Thank you!”

“This TA did a very good job at presenting the material learned in class in an easier way for us to understand. They were very responsive to emails and questions in class and seemed to have a strong knowledge of the course and material. I really feel like without this TA I would not be doing well in the course at all.”

“The discussions really helped to solidify if I was understanding the material or not. Sam was very helpful and provided a lot of examples that we got to work with peers on. This made me feel more interactive and less alone in the course. Thanks!”

CLUSTER M1CW: Food: Lens for Environment and Sustainability--Special Topics: From Fork to Future: Intersection of Health, Wealth, Culture, and Sustainability (Spring 2025)
“...I think more hands-on activities such as the teaching kitchen and researching with classmates was very valuable as I got to know my classmates better while developing my research and cooking skills.”

“...The part of class that I found most valuable were the food diary assignments, which I thought were a great way of helping to reexamine the impacts of my own diet on things like health and the environment.”

“Going into this seminar, I had high expectations, due to having a good experience in the first two quarters, and the seminar did not disappoint. The topics that were covered in the readings and lectures were interesting and relevant to what we have been learning all year.”

“It encouraged me to think critically about different problems and layers of the food system that I hadn't previously. It really widened my perspective and left me thinking throughout and taught me lessons I will take with me.”

“I really liked this seminar overall. I felt that a lot of the conversations and discussion questions were very interesting. I really liked hearing from different students within my seminar discuss their different perspectives and answers on both different and the same questions. I think it was really valuable to have that time to discuss and a lot of time to research questions about the greater themes of the seminar, as well.”

“interesting: the marketing aspect of the food system; valuable: i appreciated the holistic approach of the seminar because it meant we got to learn about basically everything about the food system”

C&EE 495: TA Training Seminar (Fall 2021-25)
“Amazing TA, the kind you have once and they ruin other class experiences for you due to the others being subpar in comparison. There's genuinely nothing I'd change about this course. Thank you again for everything!”

“You're a great instructor! Thank you for being a resource for us. I really appreciate your experience as a TA, the thoughtful discussion we had, and the wonderful content we read. Awesome job!”

“Samatha was a really great instructor! I felt like she focused on the most important aspects and takes teaching seriously. I feel much more confident in TA-ing after this class.”

“Sam was very passionate that we understand the material and was committed to us being good TAs and feeling supported. I felt very supported and very empowered to take on TAing in the future.”

“Sam had a great positive energy and shared her personal experience with us to help us be better educators.”

“Samatha did an excellent job at arranging the course material, and was very attentive to the needs of the students in her classroom. She was good at talking about how to balance work as a TA, grad student, and person, and encouraged us to set healthy boundaries with our students.”

“The instructor was good in providing information on different tools that are useful for TA's in being better instructors and also handling various situations they may encounter. I really liked the content of active learning strategies.”

“Samatha’s presentations were different and interesting. Her approach was unique and helped us learn. She was mindful of the workload on us.”

“Delivery, understanding, creates an inclusive learning environment and helps the student stay engaged through the class”

“Samatha really cares about learning and teaching, therefore the course really benefits by having her as the teacher. Classes are fun, dynamic and really helpful."

“Strengths: 1. Very understanding and empathetic towards students and their concerns. 2. Very flexible classes. 3. Gives very insightful lectures”

Syllabus Excerpt

Learning Outcomes

1. Explain the relationships between dietary patterns, cultural influences, and environmental outcomes.
2. Develop actionable strategies for addressing disparities in access to nutritious and sustainable food.
3. Synthesize insights from cultural, economic, and ecological perspectives to develop a holistic understanding of food systems.
4. Demonstrate an awareness of how privilege and systemic barriers shape individual and community food choices.
5. Commit to supporting initiatives that address inequities in food access and environmental sustainability.
6. Research credible resources to self-direct further learning on the intersection of nutrition, culture, and sustainability.

Syllabus Outline

Course Policies	*Communication, use of A.I., late submissions etc.*	
Grading Structure	**Activity/Assignment**	**Weight**
	Attendance	9%
	Class Participation	21%
	Weekly Food Diary	5%
	Weekly Writing Tasks	35%
	Final Writing Project	20%
	Writing Project Checkpoints	5%
	Final Presentation	5%
	Extra Credit	3%
	Total	**103%**
Course Schedule	*Weekly theme, assigned readings, & to-do*	
APPENDIX A	*Library resources, library team contact*	
APPENDIX B	*Community agreement*	
APPENDIX C	*A Holistic Food System Solution Report*	

- **The Questioner**
  Ask at least 2 meaningful questions on presentation day! To receive 1% you need to ask 1 meaningful question to 2 different presenters.

Course Schedule

Weekly Theme	Assigned Readings	To-do*
Week 1 Introduction	*Ch 1: Food Systems* *(Optional)*	W1 Writing Task W1 Food Diary
Week 2 Nutrition & Health	*Ch 2: Food System Public Health Effects; Ch 16: Nutrition*	W2 Writing Task W2 Food Diary
Week 3 Health & Wealth Inequities	*Ch 4: The Food System and Health Inequities* *Ch 7: Food System Economics*	W3 Writing Task W3 Food Diary
Week 4 Packaging & Consumer Behavior	*Ch 13: Food Processing and Packaging* *Ch 15: Food Consumption in the United States*	W4 Writing Task W4 Food Diary
Week 5 Culture & Marketing	*Ch 9: Food, Culture, and Society* *Ch 10: Promotional Marketing*	W5 Writing Task W5 Food Diary
Week 6 Teaching Kitchen	-	*Proposal* W6 Food Diary
Week 7 Environmental Impact	*Ch 3: Ecological Threats to and from Food Systems*	W7 Writing Task W7 Food Diary
Week 8 Sustainable & Healthy Food Environments	*Ch 17: Healthy Food Environments* *Ch 18: Intervening to Change Eating Patterns*	W8 Writing Task *Initial Draft* W8 Food Diary
Week 9 Conference Week	-	*Mandatory Conference* W9 Food Diary
Week 10 Presentation Day	-	*Final Presentation* W10 Food Diary
Finals Week	-	*Final Writing Project*

**This does not include smaller classroom activities that may vary by class.*

Example Weekly Writing Tasks

W2 Writing Task

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You have a friend called Nymeria. She is very ignorant about food contaminants and does not make good food choices.

Your task is to write a 2-page letter to this friend explaining the dangers of the specific food contaminant (assigned to you), advising them on how to reduce exposure through food choices, and providing general nutritional advice for a healthier diet.

Your letter should:

- Describe the contaminant and its sources.
- Explain the potential health dangers.
- Provide specific food choice recommendations to reduce exposure.
- Include general nutritional advice

W3 Writing Task

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NETFLIX DOCUSERIES PITCH

Audience: You're pitching to a producer at Netflix who's working on a new docuseries about how food systems shape our lives. They want fresh, powerful episode ideas that explore inequality, culture, and real-life impact. They're smart, curious, and open-minded, but they're not experts in food justice or public health.

Your Mission: Pitch an episode idea that reveals how the U.S. food system reflects and sometimes reinforces health and wealth inequities. Use what you've learned from class, the readings, and your group's specialized topic to make a case for why this story needs to be told.

Your pitch should include:

- A working title for the episode
- A short summary of the episode's focus (what story are you telling and why?)
- Key ideas or scenes that connect to this week's readings (Ch. 4 or Ch. 7)
- Something from your group's specialized topic or source
- *Optional:* include a personal angle or observation to make it feel grounded and relatable.

Length: About 2 handwritten pages. Make it vivid, persuasive, and rooted in what you've learned.

Tone: Informal but thoughtful. Imagine you're speaking directly to a producer who can green-light your episode.

W5 Writing Task

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Food Marketing De-influencer

Imagine you are a **social media influencer** who uses their platform to **protect traditional cultural foods** from being erased, diluted, or misrepresented by modern marketing.

Your goal is to persuade your audience (everyday consumers) to **appreciate and preserve authentic food traditions** instead of blindly following food trends.

For your writing task, create a **sample pitch**; something like a passionate blog post or Tiktok/Instagram Reel.

Your pitch must:

- Introduce a **specific food, food practice, or tradition that is important to a culture.**
- Briefly explain how **modern marketing has commercialized, altered, or overshadowed it.**
- Convince your audience why this **food/tradition deserves respect and authentic representation.**
- Offer at least **one action step** your followers can take to support food traditions.
- Draw on **at least 1 credible source** and weave them naturally into your pitch (not formal citations).

Teaching Feedback

Classroom Observation Form

Instructor: Samatha Arun

Course Title: Intersections of Health, Wealth, Culture, & Sustainability

Observer: Peggy Davis

Date: April 14, 2025

Review Section	Description/Comments
SUBJECT MATTER CONTENT (shows good command and knowledge of subject matter; demonstrates breadth and depth of mastery)	Strong control of subject matter; Students trusted your plan.
ORGANIZATION/INSTRUCTIONAL PLAN (organizes and presents subject matter clearly; evidences preparation; is thorough; states clear objectives; emphasizes and summarizes main points and concepts)	Clearly structured: I came in the second half but I believe there was a reading quiz and writing activity. Post-break group work with a specialized topic related to the week's theme; they found a source and discussed with each other to prepare for a share out to the class. This moved into the writing task: Netflix Docuseries pitch where each group used class topics and readings to pitch an episode related to food systems and health, wealth inequities. Paused this to move into "spider activity" related to mapping research ideas. Evidence of clear preparation.
RAPPORT/COMMUNICATION (clearly identifies goals for class and for each activity; provides feedback; encourages participation; interacts with students; shows enthusiasm)	The class seemed organized around getting students to talk and work with each other (they sat in small pods), both with the week's topics and with more creativity (Netflix pitch). They were comfortable asking questions for clarification. You were a confident guide all the way through. The pitch was a great idea and I wondered if it could have been presented as a moment to loosen up, be creative.
TEACHING METHODS & ACTIVE LEARNING (uses relevant teaching methods, materials, techniques, and technology; employs active learning components; includes variety, balance, imagination, group involvement; uses examples that are clear, precise, and appropriate; stays focused on and meets stated objectives)	Methods were useful and relevant. The primary method was small group and individual work with the objective of getting deeper into class topics. The docuseries pitch provided variety and imagination. You got them thinking about their own research with the research mapping activity. Every component had purpose.
WRITING, READING, AND/OR CRITICAL THINKING (spends significant time on writing, reading, and/critical thinking instruction as appropriate to a Writing II course; including writing as a process and scaffolded writing assignments)	The specialized topic activity took them more deeply into course topics, helping them explore it further by finding a source and to think more critically about what they found. Attention to the writing process, specifically prewriting with having them map their research ideas again (to see if anything changed from week one). The pitch activity had them writing in a more creative way with a focus on audience and tone, essential writing skills.

Review Section	Description/Comments
MANAGEMENT/ASSISTANCE TO STUDENTS (uses time wisely; attends to course interaction; responds appropriately in an engaging, inclusive learning environment)	It seems like you accomplished your goals, though the pitch activity felt a bit more compressed and there wasn't a share out, which could have been fun. You facilitated the group share outs and all topics were handled straight-forwardly. It did feel like an inclusive learning space.
CONTINUITY (content, assignments, and activities are clearly linked to specific course expectations, outcomes, and/or projects; students understand purpose of each reading/activity/assignment)	Good continuity; you are clearly helping students build a strong foundation of knowledge through readings, finding sources, and group activities. The research mapping seemed to return to and build on what they had done in the first week with an eye towards refining ideas based on new information, so they are clearly seeing that knowledge builds week to week. There was a purpose to each activity with good variety that helped students engage with topics in different ways. The research mapping will help them with the main assignment and it's good to get started early.

Strengths observed: You clearly care that students are working deeply with the ideas in your seminar, and you provide them with multiple opportunities to engage in different ways, both on their own and with their peers, which is great to see. A seminar should prioritize those peer interactions rather than always filtering through the instructor, and you seem to get that. I appreciated that when it was time to share their topics and the source they found related to it that you had everyone close their laptops and focus on what each group discovered. It highlighted that the work they completed was important and worth everyone's attention. You had a carefully planned class that enabled you to cover a lot of ground and different types of work and thinking with your students. I appreciated that you asked them to do on the spot research (to find a credible source for their group topic) and then an on the spot pitch document, using sources in a more creative way. It's important to get them working in different genres, and you did that. I also appreciated that the group work took them more deeply into course concepts such as food inequity, labor inequities in food systems, and even behavioral economics and class issues. They seemed to grasp the intersectional nature of the topics at hand and seemed able to achieve some depth with them. You were interested in what each group discovered and affirmed their work. You also took time to get them to rethink or re-center their research topic, which it seems like they started formulating week one. In this class they got to do the research mapping again with perhaps more focus and understanding of potential topics. It is clear that you prioritize an exchange of ideas and knowledge with your students and that you've created a good learning space with them.

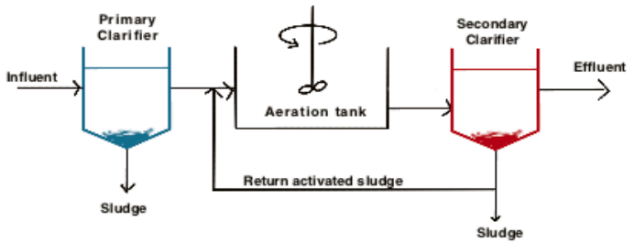
Areas for consideration: Mostly just questions here. I'm interested in how the first part of the seminar went and what the activity was, especially as it relates to writing. I appreciated having each group go deeper into a specific topic and find their own source, but after the share out there was nothing really to tie it all together that made the purpose more explicit for them, and I wondered if there could have been more cohesion there. I know maybe there was a time crunch, but it could have been a lot of fun to have the groups share out their pitch ideas for the Netflix episode. I thought that was a strong, creative activity that would have benefitted from groups seeing what their peers were doing/creating. Perhaps you should come back to this at some point (maybe you're already planning to do so). I appreciated that students were writing in various ways throughout the seminar and that you were getting them thinking about their own research topics, but the activity felt a little compressed and again I wondered if they would have benefitted from sharing topics. I know they had to hand things in at the end of class, so I'm wondering how assessment works for these activities and in general. I'm interested in how the work towards the final project is going overall. Are you happy with their progress? Finally, you might consider floating from group to group more to do check-ins and to just talk with them about the ideas being covered

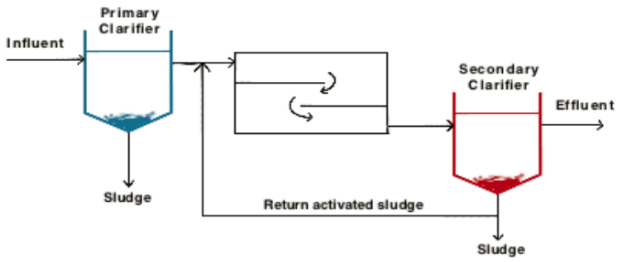
Overall impression of teaching effectiveness: You are a thoughtful and well-prepared instructor. It was good to see students engaging with each other throughout the seminar!

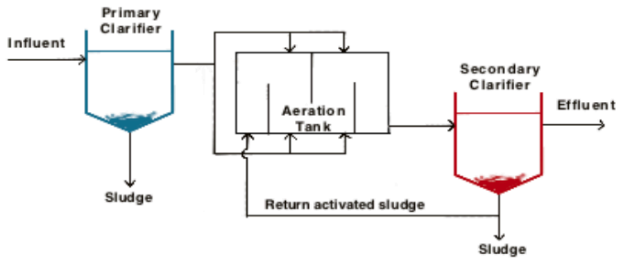
Handout 1

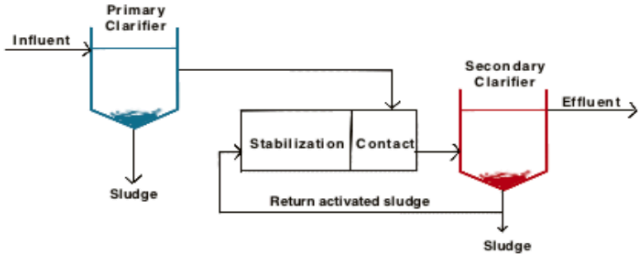
Commonly Used Activated-sludge Processes

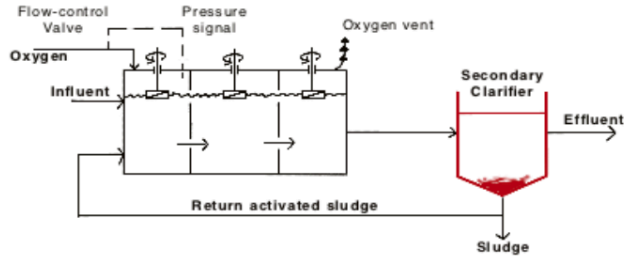
	SRT (d)	F/M Ratio (Kg BOD/Kg MLVSS-d)
Complete-mix		
1. Complete-mix activated sludge (CMAS)	3-15	0.2-0.6
Plug-flow		
2. Conventional plug flow	3-15	0.2-0.4
3. Step feed	3-15	0.2-0.4
4. Contact stabilization	5-10	0.2-0.6
5. High-purity oxygen	1-4	0.5-1.0
6. Conventional extended aeration	20-40	0.04-0.1
7. Oxidation ditch	15-30	0.04-0.1
8. Two-sludge	*Not Specified*	*Not Specified*

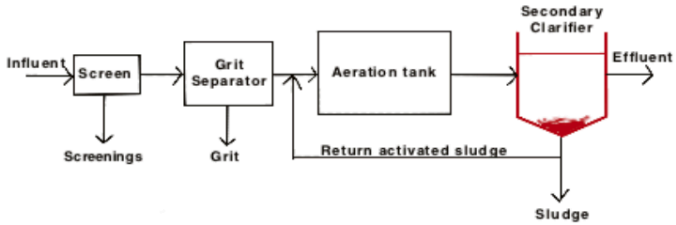


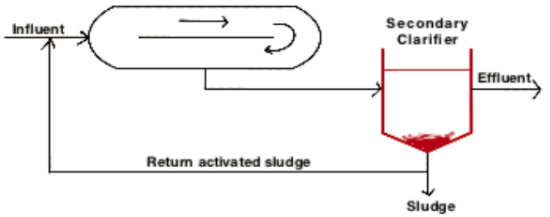


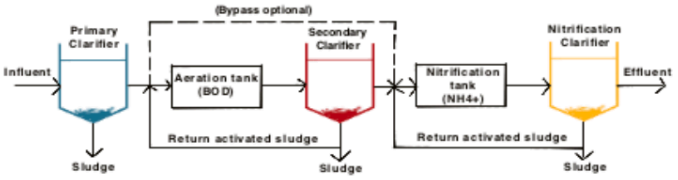








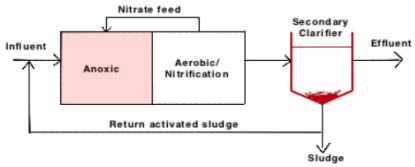




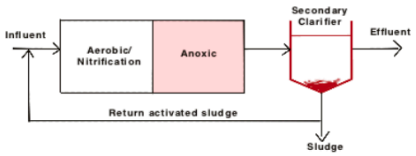
Handout 1 Continued

Types of ASP Configurations for N-removal

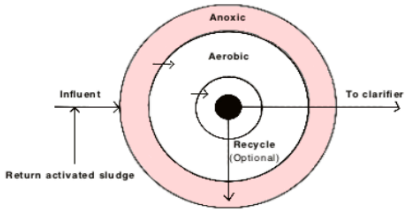
1. Preanoxic



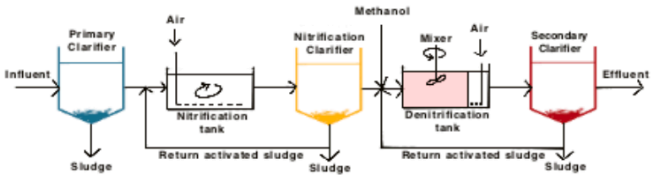
2. Postanoxic



3. Simultaneous nitrification/denitrification

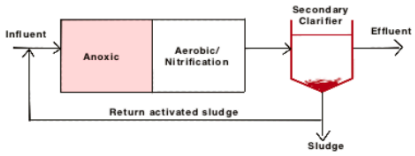


4. Two-stage nitrification-denitrification

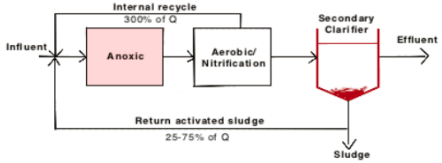


Common Preanoxic Modifications

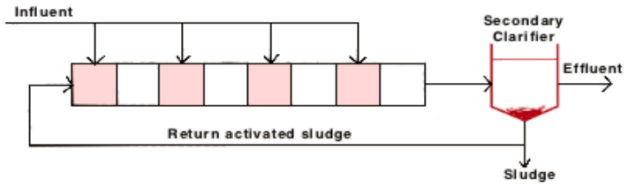
1. Ludzack-Ettinger



2. Modified Ludzack-Ettinger (MLE)

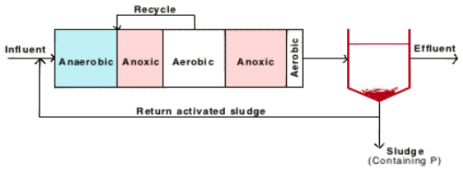


3. Step feed

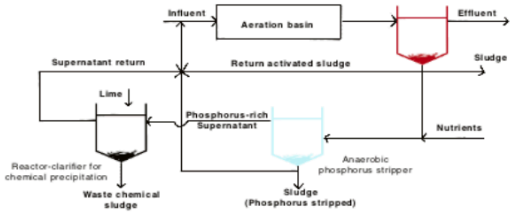


Common ASP Modifications for P-removal

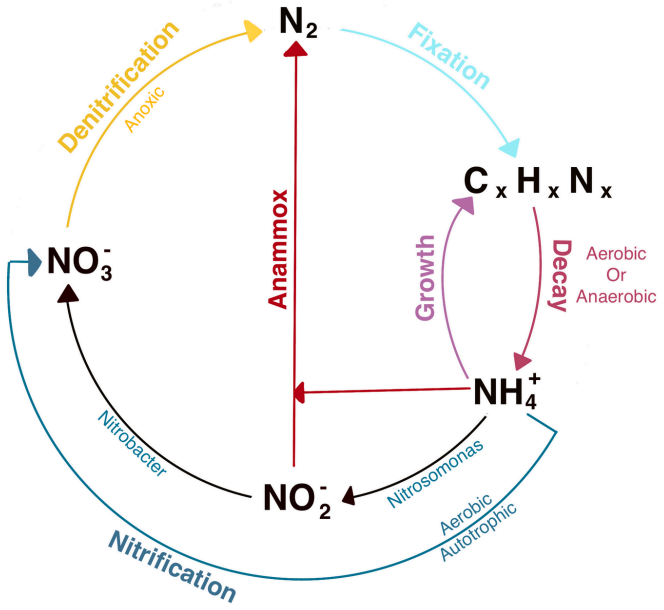
1. Modified Bardenpho (5-stage)



2. PhoStrip



Handout 2



Rubric Activity

Group A

Instructions:

Take 15 minutes to create a building from the Lego bricks you were given. After 15 minutes, you will give your building to a team in the other group for assessment.

Criteria	Poor	Average	Good
Look	Color and shape of building look ugly.	Color and shape look okay.	Color and shape look very pretty.
Shape	Building is unrealistic. It may have only one story or too many stories to be practical for its width. Building may have no windows or irregularly-placed windows.	Building is life-like, but misses some realistic touches, like doors. Building may have too few or irregularly placed windows, but not both.	Building appears to be a Lego-sized model for a real building. Windows and stories look like they fit with a real building's design.
Directions	Assignment has not been followed correctly and the building feels incomplete, and/or does not remain standing without human assistance.	Assignment has been followed mostly correctly and building feelis complete. It may have a few gaps in the walls or roof, or, though it stands on its own, it may not be a sturdy structure.	Assignment has been followed correctly. The building is clearly complete, and is strong enough to remain standing without human assistance.

Group B

GOAL: The purpose of our Lego Building project is to assess student building skills. We want to give students feedback on skills such as: meeting requirements; making necessary adjustments based on material availability and safety; preparing a polished and realistic building; and following instructions. Building a Lego Building requires each of these skills and is the task chosen for this assessment.

INSTRUCTIONS: Using at least 30 Legos, create a two-story structure that has a door and a window and is strong enough to stand on its own. The building should have cohesive design. See the rubric below for more specific criteria. After 15 minutes, you will give your building to the other group for assessment. You may ask for feedback and share resources with the other groups at your table.

Criteria	Emerging	Approaching	Proficient
Instructions (40pts)	Assignment has not been followed correctly. Uses fewer than 20 Legos, is incomplete, and/or does not remain standing without human assistance.	Assignment has been followed mostly correctly and uses between 15-25 legos, and is complete. It may have a few gaps in the walls or roof, or, though it stands on its own, it may not be a sturdy structure.	Building uses at least thirty Legos, is complete (including at least four outer walls and a roof), and stands on its own, and is strong enough to remain standing after an earthquake.
Design Requirements (45pts)	Building is unrealistic. It may have only one story or too many stories to be practical for its width. Building may have no windows or irregularly-placed windows.	Building is life-like, but misses some realistic touches, like doors. Building may have too few or irregularly placed windows or doors (but not both).	Building could exist in real life (on a larger scale), has at least two, clearly defined stories, and windows and doors placed in locations that are similar to where real windows are placed.
Aesthetic (15pts)	Color and shape of building are incohesive with no clear aesthetic.	Color and shape seem to be designed, but may be degraded due to lack of materials. Color or shape may be incohesive, but not both.	Color and shape reflect a cohesive and intentional aesthetic model.

TA Handbook Excerpts

TABLE OF CONTENTS:

PART 1 — C&EE 495 at a Glance & Other Helpful Tips!

PART 2 — Resource Inventory

PART 3 — Homework & Micro-teaching Feedback

C&EE 495 AT A GLANCE & OTHER HELPFUL TIPS!

Lay down ground rules and boundaries for classroom code of conduct in the form of community agreements. This will help in protecting both you and your students.

Should you find yourself resorting to your negative group behaviors in your work as a TA, utilize your positive group behaviors to tackle the negative ones.

Base your discussions with students' prior knowledge in mind. Be patient; especially if students need to unlearn in order to get their heads around a new topic.

It is always a good idea to send out a welcome survey. This gives you a better understanding of students' backgrounds and needs.

Be aware of internal biases that you may have inculcated. Do not think poorly of yourself for having done so, instead recognize them and strive to eliminate them.

Understand that being a student is just one role one to use in their life. People may have internal struggles that we may be unaware of. Treat your students and yourself with kindness!

Get in the habit of giving and receiving feedback. Giving students feedback allows them to improve in areas where they might be going wrong and similarly receiving constructive feedback will improve your own performance as a TA.

ENGAGEMENT TOOLKIT

Online Classroom-engagement Tools

- Mentimeter
- Kahoot!
- Zoom Polls

Click on the tools to familiarize yourself with these tools before using them during your discussion!

Old-school Classroom Engagement

- Board-work
- Tablet & Stylus

Plan your usage of board space ahead of time. Make sure that your board-work is legible and has a sense of flow to it.

A great alternative to the traditional board-work. This is particularly helpful if you plan on recording your discussions.

Presentations

Notability is a great app for both, for note-taking as well as teaching. You can also use the app to create audio recordings.

Don't worry if you don't have a tablet & Stylus at your disposal! **UCLA CLICC Library** loans out devices to both students and TAs!

Check out the slide-deck and presentation checklists above.

SAMPLE WELCOME SURVEY QUESTIONS

- Name & Preferred Name
- Pronunciation & Pronouns
- Major — OR What they majored in during their undergraduate degree (In case of grad classes)
- Do you have access to a smartphone?
- Do you have access to a laptop?
- Are you aware that UCLA CLICC Library loans laptops for student use?
- How do you feel about returning to in-person instruction?
- Are you aware that the Center for Accessible Education (CAE) helps students with disabilities secure accommodations necessary for their academic success?
- What are some questions or concerns of your regarding this course?
- Are there any resources/accommodations that I can provide you with to aid you in your learning?

The UCLA CLICC Library loans laptops, tablets, and other devices to help them in their teaching and/or learning pursuits.

The Graduate Student Association is a student government run by and for graduate students. The GSA hosts social events, advocate for policy changes on behalf of the graduate community, and basically engage in other activities benefiting the graduate community.

The Graduate Student Resource Center rolls out weekly newsletters to keep the graduate community informed about the resources and opportunities available on campus.

As your TAC for the entire academic year, it is my pleasure & privilege be of any assistance to you should you need any help navigating your role as a TA. Feel free to set up an appointment with me at any given time!

HOMEWORK & MICRO-TEACHING FEEDBACK

THE CIRTL NETWORK
CENTER FOR THE INTEGRATION OF RESEARCH, TEACHING, & LEARNING

To Whom It May Concern:

The Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning at UCLA (CIRTL@UCLA) is a member of the international CIRTL Network comprising over 40 institutions, which provide professional development for future educators in higher education to adopt inclusive, evidence-based teaching strategies. CIRTL@UCLA offers courses for graduate students, post-doctoral scholars, and early career faculty across all disciplines.

This letter confirms that by the Winter 2026 term, Samatha Arun of the University of California, Los Angeles became a certified CIRTL Associate by: 1) completing an intensive 10-session (20 total hours) *Introduction to Evidence-Based Undergraduate Teaching* course (or an equivalent course or training approved by the CIRTL@UCLA Program Director), 2) completing at least 180-minutes of additional professional development through the CIRTL Network, and 3) drafting a teaching statement. CIRTL Associates learned how to:

- Identify and describe evidence-based teaching strategies to improve learning for all undergraduate students
- Adopt an inclusive mindset and teaching practice to build and promote a student-centered learning environment
- Recognize how institutional structures and policies can impact student success and accessibility to learning
- Reflect on and describe their personal teaching philosophy
- Advance their professional development by accessing resources through the CIRTL Network

In completing the CIRTL Associate certification, Samatha Arun has joined a committed community of educators working together to transform higher education by implementing innovative, culturally-responsive pedagogy that benefits all learners.

Sincerely,

Rachel Kennison, PhD
Executive Director, CEILS
Administrative Co-Leader, CIRTL@UCLA

Benjamin Hà, PhD
Program Director, CIRTL@UCLA

Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning
Center for Education Innovation and Learning in the Sciences (CEILS)
University of California, Los Angeles
612 Charles E Young Dr. South, 222 Hershey Hall, Los Angeles, CA 90095

Hanifah Abatcha

I was a student in Samatha Arun's CEE 495 course. Here we learned effective strategies to being a competent TA as well as resources to help us do the task to the best of our ability.

Samatha Arun challenged her students by providing meaningful yet varied in-class exercises that tested the content that we learned outside of the classroom and our personal experiences. One activity that especially stood out to me was when we were learning about rubrics. We were tasked to divide into groups and build a structure out of legos based on the instructions and rubric given. However, the two groups were given two different sets of instructions and rubrics. At the end, we "graded" the other groups structure with our own rubric. We learned kinesthetically, the importance of a baseline rubric that describes the expectation for an assignment; sometimes poor performance is more about miscommunication rather than misunderstanding of content. I was also challenged by the "reverse teaching style," we were able to experience the bulk of our technical learning at home, in our own time, and came to class with the intended content at the front of our mind, confident, and ready to engage in discussion. Oftentimes as students, one of the reasons we don't engage with instructors is because we haven't had time to think about the content to develop questions or insightful thoughts, but that hurdle was removed in this class; it encouraged us to engage with our peers and Samantha herself in a far more meaningful way.

The way that Samatha gave feedback was extremely beneficial. In a subject where our performance has an impact on other people and their learning, it was especially important that we got detailed feedback about our outcome. We had a 1-on-1 meeting after our pseudo-teaching presentation where Samatha expressed to us in a respectful way things we could improve and things that went well. Before she shared her thoughts however, she asked what I thought about my presentation. That acknowledgement set a wonderful tone for the discussion in that she appreciated the time and effort I put into the presentation even if there were aspects that could be improved. As a student who went to undergrad at a very large public university, this close discussion and specialized feedback to my experience gave me tangible take-aways. I also appreciated how she encouraged us to think about our learning, the meta cognition was important to acquiring new learning, it was a creative way to bring to mind what we already knew about the course content and situates what we were learning about in class to a bigger picture.

Samatha Arun is an outstanding TA who deserves to be publicly distinguished amongst her peers because she already is distinguished from her peers! I enter a class in the CEE department and I witness little pieces of Samatha in the content of our class. The diagrams we use were made by Samatha, my peers at one point had her as a TA, she has engaged with students as well as TAs and provided resources for both demographics. It takes a special person to know how to learn and effectively teach students as well as knowing how to teach students, how to teach students; that is the kind of person who is set apart from her peers.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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Michael K. Stenstrom, Ph.D., P.E., Professor
Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering
5714 Boelter Hall
Los Angeles, CA 90095-1593
Phone: (310) 825-1408

February 5, 2026

I am writing this letter in support of Ms. Samatha Arun's nomination for the Teaching Assistant Award. I am her Ph.D. advisor and I have worked with her several times as a TA in my classes, especially CEE 255B. She has also helped me in several other classes as a volunteer. I have known her for almost five years.

Samatha has been an excellent TA, meeting and exceeding my expectations. Her comments from students are wonderful and there are too many to list here, but I list just one:

"Samatha is an exceptional teaching assistant. … Her dedication to this course, ability to synthesize difficult material I would not have learned otherwise, and willingness to interpret homework instructions for us made her far and away the best and most supportive part of the course."

I have been blessed in having such an excellent TA for my classes. She has never failed me in any of my requests. Moreover, she has anticipated the class needs and developed documents to improve the class and assist with students who are having a difficult time with the class. Specific examples are handouts with figures and text from different sources which are not as clear as they could be. She has integrated these into more efficient documents and she has done it without the need for close instruction. It is such a pleasure to have a TA that is proactive.

Her excellent TAing has been recognized by our department by having her teach candidates for TA appointments, and she has done an excellent job in this capacity. I rank her as the best TA I have had in for my classes and I give her my highest endorsement.

Very truly yours,

Michael K. Stenstrom, Ph.D., P.E., BCEE
Distinguished Professor